

Gout Flare-Up Diet: Foods to Avoid

Practical NHS-backed advice on gout flare up diet what foods to avoid.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: During a gout flare, immediately cut out high-purine foods — red meat, offal, shellfish, oily fish like sardines, and all alcohol especially beer. Drink at least 2–3 litres of water daily. These changes reduce uric acid production and help clear the crystals causing pain.

What you eat directly affects uric acid levels and gout attack frequency. During a flare, dietary changes alongside prescribed medication are the fastest route to managing symptoms.

Foods to Avoid During a Flare

High-Purine Foods (Avoid Completely)

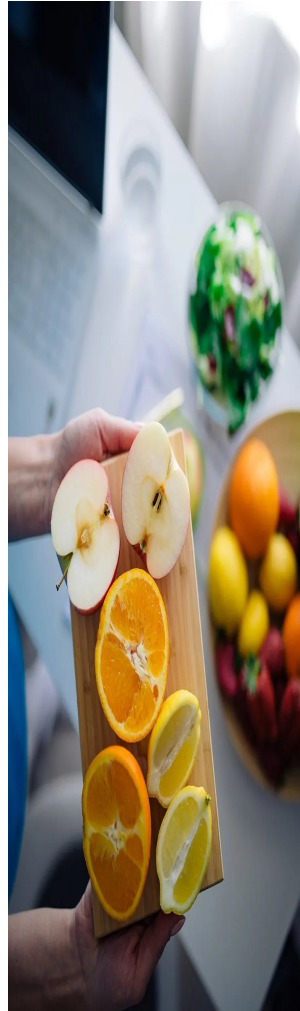
- Red meat: beef, lamb, pork
- Organ meats: liver, kidney, heart, sweetbreads
- Shellfish: prawns, crab, mussels, scallops
- Oily fish: sardines, anchovies, mackerel, herring
- Meat extracts: gravy, Marmite, meat stock

Drinks to Avoid

- All alcohol — especially beer (highest purine content)
- Sugary drinks and fruit juices (fructose raises uric acid)

- Energy drinks
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Foods That Help During a Flare



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Tart cherry juice is particularly well-studied — regular consumption is associated with a 35% reduction in gout attack risk. Low-fat dairy actively lowers uric acid. Drink 2–3 litres of water daily to help kidneys flush uric acid.

Foods to Eat More Of

- Tart cherry juice or fresh cherries
- Skimmed milk and low-fat dairy
- Vegetables (all are low in purines)
- Whole grains, oats, bread, rice, pasta

- Eggs and tofu (low-purine protein alternatives)
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Q&A;

Question: Can I eat any seafood during a gout flare? **Short answer:** White fish (cod, haddock, plaice) are lower in purines and can usually be eaten in moderate amounts. Avoid all shellfish and oily fish during a flare.

Question: Does cutting out purine foods alone stop a flare? **Short answer:** Diet helps but is rarely sufficient alone during an acute flare. Your GP can prescribe colchicine or NSAIDs which work faster. Diet changes are most valuable for preventing future attacks.

Question: How much water should I drink during a gout flare? **Short answer:** Aim for 2–3 litres daily. Dehydration is a known trigger for gout attacks, and hydration helps your kidneys excrete uric acid more effectively.